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People of the Lost River

As we move from prehistory to history, we are immediately confronted by a problem of plenty. The early history of India has two parallel sources, but there is a great deal of disagreement about how they fit together. On one hand there is the archaeological evidence of the sophisticated cities of the Harappan Civilization (also called Indus Valley or Indus–Saraswati civilization). On the other hand, there is the literature of the Vedic tradition. Their geographies and timelines roughly overlap but archaeologists and historians have long had difficulty reconciling them. Indeed, this has remained a hot topic of discussion among scholars and often deteriorates into a political debate. I do not claim to have resolved the debate. Therefore, I will tell the two stories separately. I will then focus on the one thing that the two sources agree on: the drying of a great river that the Rig Veda calls the Saraswati. No matter which way one looks at it, the drying of this river was an important geographical event that defined early India.

THE HARAPPAN CIVILIZATION

Till the early twentieth century, as already discussed in the previous chapter, it was believed that Indian civilization began with the ‘Aryan Invasions’ that were supposed to have taken place around 1500 BC. These European-like Aryans were supposed to have come from Central Asia and to have conquered the subcontinent and then ‘civilized’ the native population. It should not be lost on the reader that this theory evolved in an intellectual